

# Ancient-Medieval History

## Till Maurya (Prehistory- 185 BC)

Exam: UPSC CSE (Prelims)

### 1. Pre-history

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 1.852 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 2 • Year span: 2020–2024 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:29

### TopicDemandMap: Pre-history (Ancient-Medieval History > Till Maurya > Pre-history)

#### Explicitly Tested Subtopics

##### 1. Stone Age Tool Typology and Cultural Variation

- **Evidence:** [4756]
- **Notes:**
  - Focus on how Stone Age periods are classified based on stone tool types and technologies.
  - Emphasis on the presence or absence of regional and chronological variation in tool-making.
  - Tests understanding of whether cultural evolution was uniform or diverse across the subcontinent.

##### 2. Identification and Matching of Prehistoric and Protohistoric Archaeological Sites

- **Evidence:** [1136]
- **Notes:**
  - Requires knowledge of major archaeological sites, their correct state locations, and cultural attributions (e.g., Chalcolithic, Megalithic).
  - Tests ability to match sites with their period/cultural phase and geographical context.

#### Logical Study Sequence

##### 1 Stone Age Tool Typology and Cultural Variation

- Foundational understanding of how prehistory is divided and characterized.

##### 1 Identification and Matching of Prehistoric and Protohistoric Archaeological Sites

- Application of foundational knowledge to specific sites and their cultural attributions.

## Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic chronological framework of Indian prehistory (Paleolithic, Mesolithic, Neolithic, Chalcolithic, Megalithic).
- Understanding of archaeological terminology (e.g., Chalcolithic, Megalithic).
- Familiarity with the geographical distribution of key archaeological sites.
- Ability to distinguish between different prehistoric and protohistoric cultural phases.

## Adjacent Subtopics

- Detailed features and significance of specific prehistoric sites (e.g., tools, art, habitation patterns).
- Methods of prehistoric archaeology (dating techniques, excavation methods).
- Subsistence patterns and lifestyle of prehistoric communities (hunter-gatherer, early agriculture).
- Transition from prehistory to protohistory (emergence of metallurgy, early settlements).
- Comparative analysis of Indian prehistory with global prehistoric developments.

## Notes

- The PYQ count is limited (2 questions), so subdivision is minimal and broad.
- Current demand focuses on classification of prehistory and factual knowledge of sites and their cultural attributions.
- No direct questions on prehistoric art, subsistence, or archaeological methods in the given span, but these remain logical adjacent areas for future questions.

## 2. Indus Valley Civilization

Tier: **tier1** • Weightage: **7.407** • Total Qs: **0** • PYQs: **15** • Year span: **1994–2021** • Model: **gpt-4.1** • Updated: **2026-01-07 13:28**

### TopicDemandMap: Indus Valley Civilization (Prehistory–185 BC)

## Explicitly Tested Subtopics

### 1. Major Sites and Their Features

- **Evidence:** 1473, 4758, 658, 833
- **Notes:**
- Questions focus on identification and matching of key Harappan sites (e.g., Lothal, Kalibangan, Dholavira, Kot Diji) with their distinctive features such as dockyards, water management, and location.

- Also includes distinguishing Harappan sites from non-Harappan ones.

## 2. Artefacts and Material Culture

- **Evidence:** 4557, 4768, 4755
- **Notes:**
- Tested aspects include earliest use of materials (silver), distinctive artefacts (steatite seals, standardized bricks), and mass production of tools (limestone and chert blades).

## 3. Art, Iconography, and Represented Animals

- **Evidence:** 1345
- **Notes:**
- Focus on animals depicted (or not depicted) in Harappan seals and terracotta art, reflecting cultural and religious symbolism.

## 4. Chronological and Cultural Associations

- **Evidence:** 1346, 1996
- **Notes:**
- Questions test knowledge of correct associations between Harappan Civilization and related archaeological cultures or artefacts, as well as its geographical context.

## 5. Urban Planning and Architecture

- **Evidence:** 4764, 833
- **Notes:**
- Emphasis on features like street layout, brick standardization, and advanced water management systems.

## 6. Economy and Technology

- **Evidence:** 2700, 4755
- **Notes:**
- Includes questions on textile production (cotton), mass production of tools, and trade-related artefacts.

## 7. Religion and Social Structure

- **Evidence:** 2700, 46
- **Notes:**

- Focus on the secular or religious nature of the civilization, worship practices, and presence or absence of temples and deities.

## **8. Script and Writing**

- **Evidence:** 4763, 1473
- **Notes:**
- Tested knowledge of the Harappan script, its direction, and early inscriptions.

## **9. Distinctive Features and Firsts**

- **Evidence:** 4763, 4768
- **Notes:**
- Questions on what makes the civilization unique (first cities, use of script, artefacts).

## **10. Comparative and Peripheral Sites**

- **Evidence:** 838
- **Notes:**
- Tests ability to distinguish Harappan features from those of contemporary or geographically related cultures.

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## **Logical Study Sequence**

- 1 Chronological and Cultural Associations**
- 2 Major Sites and Their Features**
- 3 Urban Planning and Architecture**
- 4 Artefacts and Material Culture**
- 5 Economy and Technology**
- 6 Art, Iconography, and Represented Animals**
- 7 Religion and Social Structure**
- 8 Script and Writing**
- 9 Distinctive Features and Firsts**
- 10 Comparative and Peripheral Sites**

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## Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic understanding of archaeological terminology (e.g., artefact, site, seal, terracotta)
- Knowledge of Indian geography and river systems (for site locations)
- Familiarity with chronology and periodization of ancient Indian history
- Ability to distinguish between Harappan and non-Harappan cultures/sites
- Understanding of material culture and its interpretation in archaeology
- Awareness of comparative features among ancient civilizations

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## Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Detailed study of Harappan script: decipherment attempts, content, and significance
- Trade networks: internal and external trade, maritime contacts
- Decline of the Indus Valley Civilization: theories and evidence
- Social organization: evidence for governance, administration, and class structure
- Technological innovations: metallurgy, urban sanitation, and measurement systems
- Environmental and ecological context: climate, river changes, and their impact
- Comparative analysis with contemporary civilizations (Mesopotamia, Egypt)
- Recent archaeological discoveries and their implications

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## Notes

- The subtopics above are strictly derived from the given PYQ set. Some areas (e.g., decline, trade networks) are not directly tested but are logical extensions.
- The PYQ set is sufficiently diverse to allow for meaningful subdivision, but some subtopics (e.g., religion, script) are tested in a limited manner.
- Overlap exists between certain subtopics (e.g., artefacts and distinctive features), but they are separated here for conceptual clarity based on question focus.
- No full question texts or options are reproduced; only conceptual patterns are mapped.

## 3. Vedic Age

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 3.704 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 14 • Year span: 1995–2020 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:30

## TopicDemandMap: Vedic Age (Prehistory–185 BC)

## Explicitly Tested Subtopics

### 1. Vedic Literature and Hymns

- **Evidence:** 4555, 1749, 4761
- **Notes:** Questions focus on the composers of Vedic hymns, identification of specific Vedas and their contents (e.g., magical charms in Atharva Veda), and hymns related to social customs (e.g., marriage in the Rigveda).

### 2. Geography and Rivers in Vedic Texts

- **Evidence:** 4553
- **Notes:** Tested knowledge of rivers most frequently mentioned in early Vedic literature, reflecting the geographical context of the Vedic people.

### 3. Social Structure and Terminology

- **Evidence:** 4554, 4770
- **Notes:** Questions address Vedic social units (e.g., kula, vansha, gotra) and prescribed duties of varnas (e.g., Vaishyas according to Dharmashastras).

### 4. Religious Beliefs and Practices

- **Evidence:** 2708, 2781
- **Notes:** Focus on central concepts like dharma and rita, and the nature of early Vedic religion (e.g., worship of nature, yajnas).

### 5. Political Organization and Leadership

- **Evidence:** 4762
- **Notes:** Examines the nature of Vedic political structures, the role of the Rajan, and the distinction between kingship and tribal chiefship.

### 6. Science and Mathematics in Vedic Period

- **Evidence:** 2250
- **Notes:** Assesses awareness of mathematical knowledge in Vedic texts (e.g., Baudhayan theorem and Sulva Sutras).

### 7. Comparison with Contemporary Civilizations

- **Evidence:** 478
- **Notes:** Compares aspects of Rigvedic Aryans with Indus Valley Civilization (e.g., warfare, metallurgy, domestication of animals).

## 8. Religious and Philosophical Terminology

- **Evidence:** 792, 2685
- **Notes:** Tests understanding of terms like Parivrajaka, Shramana, Upasaka, and philosophical concepts (e.g., creation and maintenance of the world in Jain philosophy).

## 9. Chronology and Historical Sequencing

- **Evidence:** 1751
- **Notes:** Requires knowledge of the chronological order of major religious-philosophical figures (though this question is more broadly about Indian philosophy, it includes Vedic roots).

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## Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Geography and Rivers in Vedic Texts
- 2 Vedic Literature and Hymns
- 3 Religious Beliefs and Practices
- 4 Social Structure and Terminology
- 5 Political Organization and Leadership
- 6 Science and Mathematics in Vedic Period
- 7 Religious and Philosophical Terminology
- 8 Comparison with Contemporary Civilizations
- 9 Chronology and Historical Sequencing

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## Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Familiarity with the structure and content of the four Vedas
- Basic understanding of Vedic Sanskrit terms and their meanings
- Awareness of the socio-political and religious context of the Vedic period
- Ability to distinguish between early and later Vedic phases

- Knowledge of the broader timeline of ancient Indian history for comparative and chronological questions
- Understanding of the evolution of religious and philosophical ideas in ancient India

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### Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Transition from Early to Later Vedic Age (changes in society, polity, religion)
- Vedic economy (agriculture, cattle rearing, trade)
- Role and status of women in Vedic society beyond hymn composition
- Development and significance of Vedic rituals and sacrifices
- Education and transmission of Vedic knowledge (gurukulas, oral tradition)
- Archaeological evidence and material culture of the Vedic period
- Interactions with other contemporary cultures and tribes
- Evolution of language and script in the Vedic period

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### Notes

- The subtopics above are strictly derived from the provided PYQs; no external syllabus or textbook structure has been imported.
- Some subtopics (e.g., science/mathematics, chronology) are represented by single questions, indicating limited but notable demand.
- The number of PYQs is moderate; further subdivision is possible but some areas (e.g., religious terminology, social structure) are broad due to the nature of the questions.
- Adjacent subtopics are suggested based on logical extensions of current UPSC questioning patterns, not on external lists.

## 4. Mahajanpada

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 3.704 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 8 • Year span: 1994–2022 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:28

### TopicDemandMap: Mahajanpada (Ancient-Medieval History > Till Maurya > Mahajanpada)

#### Explicitly Tested Subtopics



## **1. Identification and Features of Mahajanapadas**

- Evidence: [4766, 4769]
- Notes:
- Questions test recognition of the sixteen Mahajanapadas as listed in ancient texts.
- Includes distinguishing which states were part of the canonical list and general features (e.g., their political structures, geographic spread).

## **2. Political Systems: Gana/Sangha (Oligarchies) vs Monarchies**

- Evidence: [4754]
- Notes:
- Focus on differentiating between oligarchic and monarchical Mahajanapadas.
- Tests knowledge of which Mahajanapadas were governed as gana-sanghas (oligarchies).

## **3. Association of Kingdoms with the Life of the Buddha**

- Evidence: [226, 140]
- Notes:
- Questions require identifying which Mahajanapadas were significant in the context of Buddha's life and activities.
- Emphasizes the historical geography of Buddhism.

## **4. Commonalities and Differences between Buddhism and Jainism**

- Evidence: [2730]
- Notes:
- Tests understanding of doctrinal similarities and differences between Buddhism and Jainism, especially in relation to Vedic authority and ritual practices.
- Although not directly about Mahajanapadas, reflects the intellectual milieu of the period.

## **5. Biographical Details of Key Religious Figures (Mahavira, Buddha, Parshvanatha)**

- Evidence: [1610]
- Notes:
- Focus on familial and regional backgrounds of major religious leaders associated with the Mahajanapada era.

## **6. Jain Heritage and Patronage (Gommateshwara Statue)**

- Evidence: [4558]
- Notes:
- Tests awareness of Jain monuments and their patrons, indirectly reflecting the religious landscape of the Mahajanapada period.

## **Logical Study Sequence**

- 1 Identification and Features of Mahajanapadas
- 2 Political Systems: Gana/Sangha (Oligarchies) vs Monarchies
- 3 Association of Kingdoms with the Life of the Buddha
- 4 Commonalities and Differences between Buddhism and Jainism
- 5 Biographical Details of Key Religious Figures
- 6 Jain Heritage and Patronage

## **Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites**

- Understanding of the socio-political structure of ancient India (janapada, mahajanapada, monarchy, oligarchy).
- Familiarity with the religious and philosophical developments during the Mahajanapada period.
- Basic geographical knowledge of ancient Indian kingdoms.
- Awareness of the role of religious figures and their interactions with political entities.
- Ability to interpret information from ancient texts (Buddhist and Jaina sources).

## **Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)**

- Economic systems and urbanization in Mahajanapada period.
- Military organization and warfare among Mahajanapadas.
- Interactions and conflicts between Mahajanapadas.
- Administrative systems and taxation.
- Role of women and social stratification in Mahajanapada society.
- Archaeological evidence and material culture from Mahajanapada sites.

## **Notes**

- The subtopics above are strictly derived from the provided PYQs; no external syllabus content has been introduced.

- The number of PYQs (8) allows for moderate subdivision, but some subtopics (e.g., religious developments) are broad due to overlapping question patterns.
- Some questions test overlapping knowledge (e.g., political and religious history), reflecting the integrated nature of UPSC's approach to this period.

## 5. Maurya Empire

Tier: tier1 • Weightage: 9.259 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 19 • Year span: 1991–2023 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:29

### TopicDemandMap: Maurya Empire (Ancient-Medieval History > Till Maurya > Maurya Empire)

#### Explicitly Tested Subtopics

##### 1. Chronology and Foundational Events

- **Evidence:** 1236, 4550
- Focus on the political context at the time of Alexander's invasion and the chronological order of foreign visitors, especially Megasthenes' association with the Mauryan court.

##### 2. Key Personalities and Literature

- **Evidence:** 4559, 1475
- Identification of Chanakya (Kautilya) and his alternate names; significance of the Mudrarakshasa play in depicting Mauryan court politics.

##### 3. Mauryan Administration and Society (as per Arthashastra)

- **Evidence:** 961
- Social and legal structures, especially slavery and legal status, as described in Kautilya's Arthashastra.

##### 4. Mauryan Inscriptions and Edicts: Content and Geography

- **Evidence:** 4562, 4556, 4560, 992
- Content of Ashokan edicts (mention of South Indian kingdoms), titles used by Ashoka, inscriptions evidencing Mauryan control (e.g., Girnar), and the matching of edict sites with modern locations.

##### 5. Ashoka: Policies, Titles, and Religious Attitude

- **Evidence:** 751, 4765, 1233

- Ashoka's religious policies (tolerance, advice to subjects), transformation after Kalinga War, and motivations for Kalinga's annexation.

## 6. Mauryan Empire: Extent and Political Geography

- **Evidence:** 4551
- Territorial extent of the Mauryan Empire, especially under Ashoka.

## 7. Art, Architecture, and Symbolism

- **Evidence:** 659, 1003
- Relief sculptures and inscriptions mentioning Ashoka (e.g., Kanganahalli), and the concept, function, and origin of stupas in Buddhist tradition.

## 8. Foreign Accounts and Observations

- **Evidence:** 4757
- Observations by Greek travelers regarding Indian agriculture and society.

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## Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Chronology and Foundational Events
- 2 Key Personalities and Literature
- 3 Mauryan Administration and Society (as per Arthashastra)
- 4 Mauryan Inscriptions and Edicts: Content and Geography
- 5 Ashoka: Policies, Titles, and Religious Attitude
- 6 Mauryan Empire: Extent and Political Geography
- 7 Art, Architecture, and Symbolism
- 8 Foreign Accounts and Observations

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## Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Understanding of ancient Indian chronology and dynastic succession.
- Familiarity with major ancient Indian texts (Arthashastra, Buddhist literature).
- Basic knowledge of epigraphy and the significance of inscriptions.

- Awareness of the interaction between political history and religious developments (e.g., Buddhism's spread).
- Geographical literacy regarding ancient and modern Indian regions.
- Ability to interpret historical sources (literary, archaeological, and foreign accounts).

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### **Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)**

- Detailed administrative structure of the Mauryan Empire (e.g., provincial governance, bureaucracy).
- Economic policies and trade under the Mauryas.
- Role and status of women in Mauryan society.
- Decline and disintegration of the Mauryan Empire.
- Comparative analysis of Mauryan and post-Mauryan polities (e.g., Sungas).
- Further exploration of Mauryan art forms beyond stupas (e.g., pillars, capitals).
- Mauryan relations with Hellenistic kingdoms and other contemporaneous powers.

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### **Notes**

- The PYQ set is sufficiently broad to allow for meaningful subdivision, but some subtopics (e.g., administration, economy) are only indirectly referenced.
- Questions are heavily weighted towards Ashoka, his inscriptions, and religious policy, with less direct focus on other Mauryan rulers or detailed administrative mechanisms.
- Some questions (e.g., on foreign visitors or Buddhist structures) require cross-linking knowledge of broader ancient Indian history.
- The map reflects only what has been tested; actual syllabus coverage may be broader.

## **6. Sangam Age**

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 1.852 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 2 • Year span: 2018–2023 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:29

### **TopicDemandMap: Sangam Age (Ancient-Medieval History > Till Maurya (Prehistory-185 BC) > Sangam Age)**

#### **Explicitly Tested Subtopics**

## 1. Literary Sources and Languages

- **Description:** Identification of languages in which key Sangam-related texts (e.g., Jataka tales) were composed.
- **Evidence:** [4759]

## 2. Social and Cultural Practices

- **Description:** Understanding specific social customs or practices referenced in Sangam literature (e.g., ritual suicide such as 'Vattakirutal').
- **Evidence:** [1005]

## Logical Study Sequence

### 1 Literary Sources and Languages

(Foundational: Knowing the textual and linguistic basis of the Sangam Age)

### 1 Social and Cultural Practices

(Builds on literary sources to interpret societal norms and customs)

## Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- **Familiarity with Sangam Literature:**

Recognition of major Sangam texts and their thematic content.

- **Basic Chronology of Ancient India:**

Placing the Sangam Age within the broader timeline of Indian history.

- **Understanding of Ancient Indian Languages:**

Differentiating among languages like Tamil, Sanskrit, Pali, and their literary traditions.

- **Interpretation of Literary References:**

Ability to connect poetic or textual references to historical practices.

## Adjacent Subtopics

- **Political Structure and Administration:**

Forms of governance, kingship, and political organization during the Sangam Age.

- **Economic Activities:**

Trade, agriculture, and occupational groups as described in Sangam texts.

- **Religious Beliefs and Practices:**

Deities, rituals, and religious life in the Sangam period.

- **Geographical Extent and Urban Centers:**

Major regions, cities, and their significance in Sangam literature.

- **Role of Women and Gender Relations:**

Status and roles of women as depicted in Sangam poems.

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**Notes:**

- The PYQ count is limited (2 questions), restricting the granularity of subtopic mapping.
- Current demand focuses on literary identification and interpretation of cultural practices, but does not yet cover political, economic, or broader social aspects.
- Adjacent subtopics are suggested based on logical progression from tested areas, not on direct PYQ evidence.